

SELF-LOADING PISTOLS (1925–45)

In the years following World War I, military forces worldwide began adopting self-loading pistols for use by their officer corps. While some were intended solely for personal defense, others, such as the Browning High Power or GP35, were dual-purpose weapons suitable for offensive operations due to their caliber and magazine capacity.

▼ NAMBU TAISHO 14

Date 1920
Origin Japan
Barrel 4in (12cm)
Caliber 8mm Nambu

The first Nambu pistols appeared in 1909. Although they were clearly influenced by the Luger P.08 (see p.168), they have nothing in common with it internally, the unlocking of the bolt from the barrel being achieved by the rotation of a linking block.



▲ ASTRA MODEL 901

Date 1927
Origin Spain
Barrel 6¼in (16cm)
Caliber 7.63mm Mauser

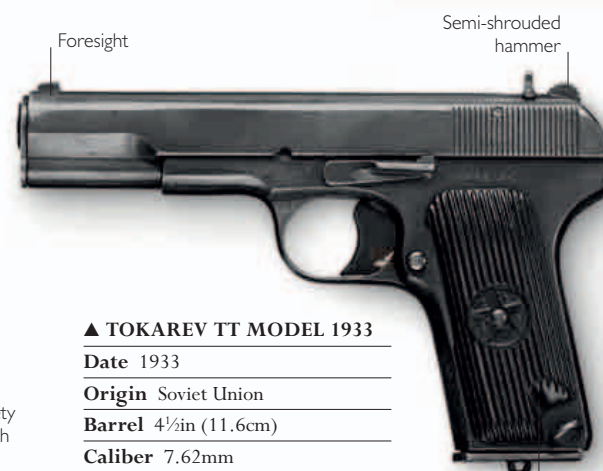
This self-loading pistol was part of the Astra 900 series, a copy of the *Schnellfeuer* ("Rapidfire") version of the Mauser C.96 (see p.165). It could switch between semiautomatic and automatic firing modes. In fully automatic mode, the gun would keep firing as long as the trigger was kept pulled. The gun was, however, difficult to control in that mode.



▲ WALTHER PPK

Date 1931
Origin Germany
Barrel 3¼in (8.3cm)
Caliber 7.65mm

The Walther PPK was popularized through its cinematic use by James Bond, and it did indeed find its way into many security service hands, mainly because of its compact dimensions. It was a simple recoil weapon most commonly produced in .32in ACP (7.65mm) caliber, and was fed from a seven-round magazine.

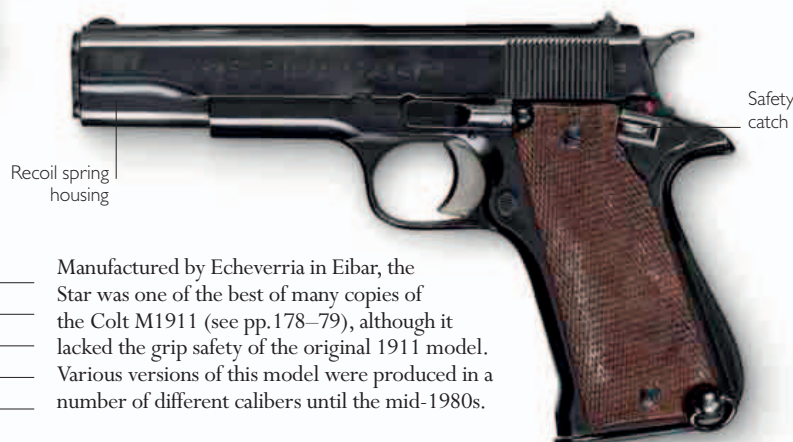


▲ TOKAREV TT MODEL 1933

Date 1933
Origin Soviet Union
Barrel 4½in (11.6cm)
Caliber 7.62mm

The Tokarev TT was the first self-loading pistol on general issue to the Red Army. In design, it was similar to the Browning GP35 (right), with a similar recoil-driven self-loading action. It was simple and could be field-stripped without tools. It lacked a safety catch.

Butt houses eight-round removable box magazine



► STAR MODEL M

Date 1932
Origin Spain
Barrel 5in (12.5cm)
Caliber 9mm Largo

Manufactured by Echeverria in Eibar, the Star was one of the best of many copies of the Colt M1911 (see pp.178–79), although it lacked the grip safety of the original 1911 model. Various versions of this model were produced in a number of different calibers until the mid-1980s.